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Jewish Candidates Eye 45th District Seat

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Author: Aaron Bandler | Section: News | 441 Words
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Jewish candidates are in the field for a special election on April 3 for the state Assembly seat for the 45th District, which encompasses Calabasas, Northridge and Encino.

The seat became vacant when Assemblyman Matt Dababneh (D-Woodland Hills) stepped down following allegations of sexual misconduct in December 2017. Dababneh denied the allegations but wrote in his resignation letter that it was "time for me to move on to new opportunities. It'd be very hard for me to represent my district and be able to pass the type of legislation that would be meaningful."

Dababneh's resignation followed the departure of another San Fernando Valley representative, 39th District Assemblyman Raul Bocanegra, who resigned his seat in light of sexual harassment allegations in November.

"We just need new people up there [at the state Capitol]," said Democrat Jesse Gabriel, an attorney, a board member of the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles and one of two Jewish candidates in the eight-candidate field. "There's clearly a systemic cultural issue, and we need a different group of folks up there."

The other candidates are Ankur Patel, C.R. Cochrane, Daniel Brin, Jeff Bornstein, Tricia Robbins Kasson and Ray Bishop, all Democrats; and Republican Justin Clark. Cochrane is running as a write-in candidate. Former Los Angeles City Councilman Dennis Zine dropped out of the race, but his name will still be on the ballot. If no candidate receives an outright majority, the top two vote-getters, regardless of party affiliation, will advance to a June 5 runoff election.

"We just have a lot of grass-roots energy. I think there are a lot of people who are ready for new leadership in Sacramento and are excited to get behind our campaign." — Jesse Gabriel

Despite the large field, Gabriel is widely seen as the front-runner, having raised more than $500,000 for his campaign. He also has the backing of U.S. Rep. Brad Sherman (D-Porter Ranch), Los Angeles City Councilman Paul Koretz and more than 50 Jewish community leaders.

"We just have a lot of grass-roots energy," Gabriel said. "I think there are a lot of people who are ready for new leadership in Sacramento and are excited to get behind our campaign."

Brin, the other known Jewish candidate and a self-described progressive Democrat, said he believes he can attract enough support to win based on his experience working with people of varying political stripes through his position as president of the West Hills Neighborhood Council and as a member of the Canoga Park-West Hills Chamber of Commerce.

"I've demonstrated the ability to work with people of all different backgrounds and political beliefs to build something positive and good for our neighborhood," the 64-year-old Brin said. "And I can do the same [for the district]."

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